



Disunited we STAND

INDIA IS TOO HUGE TO BE
TYPECAST. UNITY IS THE LAST
REFUGE OF THOSE WHO ARE
TERRIFIED OF DIFFERENCE.

BY PICO IYER

Ten years ago, many Indians and foreigners were busily laying down principles for Indian writing in English, or hatching theories about it. It was, at least to Western eyes, exotic in its material, larger-than-life, full of events that strained the traditional boundaries of straight realism. It trafficked in the mythical patterns, the gods that are a daily feature of much of Indian life, even as it read, often, like the product of an arranged marriage between Charles Dickens and Jane Austen. At the very least, it was decidedly different from the literature of London or New York. Indian writing in English was already decades-old at that point, and India was 50 years away from its colonial past. But "Indian writing" seemed rare enough and strange enough to be confined within a literary ghetto.

No more. What does Salman Rushdie have in common with Rohinton Mistry (and what did they have in common, deep down, even then)? What can you say about Jhumpa Lahiri that could possibly apply to Kiran Desai (other than that both write about family and the complications of belonging, akin to saying that both have two eyes and two ears)? Would you even include Jhumpa Lahiri in the category of Indian writing, given that she has spent so little time in India and sets nearly all her stories on the East Coast of America? To what extent, indeed, does Indian writing have to deal with India at all (were it not for the author's name and photograph, there is not a word in Vikram Seth's *An Equal Music* that would suggest an Indian origin)?

In desperation, category-makers and theorists began extending the grouping to what was called South Asian writing, or "sub-altern" fiction or even post-



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